

Psycho-Cybernetics

A New Technique for Using Your Subconscious Power

Maxwell Maltz

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

How do you get more living out of your life when effort and willpower have stopped producing it?

THE CENTRAL ANSWER

You are operating an impersonal, goal-striving mechanism that steers toward whatever picture you hold most vividly — above all your picture of yourself. Change the picture, correct the beliefs feeding it, and then stop interfering with the machinery you have set in motion.

THE FRAMEWORK

The SUCCESS Personality

The profile of a properly functioning personality packs into the letters of the word success itself. Seven components, each a condition the mechanism needs in order to run.

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- S** **Sense of direction**
A goal-seeking mechanism without a goal goes in circles. Get a project, not just an intention, and hold at least one impersonal goal alongside the personal ones.
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- U** **Understanding**
You cannot respond appropriately to faulty information. Seek the truth about yourself and others whether the news is good or bad. It does not matter who is right, but what is right.
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- C** **Courage**
Only action turns a goal into a reality, and nothing is guaranteed. The difference is often not better ideas but the willingness to bet on them.
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- C** **Charity**
Regard for other people as people rather than as pawns in your game. Grounded religiously and also practically: people are important, and treating them otherwise is an error about reality.
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- E** **Esteem**
The word means to appreciate the worth of. Appreciating your own worth is not egotism unless you also claim credit for having made yourself.
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- S** **Self-confidence**
Built on the experience of success. The brain reinforces hits and lets misses go — so bank the hits deliberately.
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- S** **Self-acceptance**
Coming to terms with yourself as you are now, faults included. The negatives belong to you; they are not you.

THE INSIGHTS

Six that carry the book

1 The mechanism is impersonal

Your brain and nervous system operate as a servo-mechanism — a self-correcting guidance system that steers toward a target and adjusts from feedback along the way. This is Maltz's mechanical model of the mind rather than settled physiology, and everything else rests on it. The mechanism has no preference about which target it is given.

Present it with goals of success and it functions as a success mechanism. Present it with goals of failure and it functions as a failure mechanism, with identical faithfulness and identical efficiency. Nothing inside it registers the difference.

The question stops being whether you are a success type or a failure type. It becomes: what have I loaded as the target?

2 The self-image prescribes the area of the possible

Of all the mental pictures the mechanism works from, one governs the rest — your picture of the kind of person you are. It does not set what you deserve. It sets what is available to you at all, and goals outside it are ruled out quietly, before effort is ever considered.

Whatever the method of therapy, a person must see himself in a new role before he can change. The picture moves first, and behavior follows it.

Work on the image rather than on willpower — and note which direction the usual error runs. Maltz holds that most people underrate themselves, and that the apparent superiority complex is a cover story for inferiority.

3 A vivid rehearsal registers as an experience

Maltz's central mechanical claim is that the nervous system cannot tell the difference between an actual experience and one vividly imagined in detail. The whole method depends on it.

Napoleon soldiered in his imagination for years before reaching a battlefield. Conrad Hilton played at running a hotel as a boy, long before he owned one.

Thirty minutes of detailed rehearsal is training, not daydreaming — and the reverse follows. Worry, pictured vividly and repeated, is the same training aimed at the wrong outcome.

4 **Conscious thought is the control knob**

The automatic mechanism has no will of its own and holds no opinions about you. It works only on the data you supply — ideas, beliefs, interpretations, opinions. Which means changing a stuck behavior does not require excavating the unconscious.

The unhelpful patterns were installed by conscious thought in the first place — irrational and unrealistic thought, but conscious. What conscious thought built, conscious thought can revise.

You can interrogate a belief directly rather than dig for its origin. It also means dwelling on a past error makes that error the goal image the mechanism now steers toward.

5 **Past the decision, effort becomes interference**

The forebrain poses and identifies problems; it was never engineered to solve them. And in any guidance system, correction is meant to modify forward action, not to stop it.

Darwin's solution arrived in a carriage after months of conscious effort had failed. And the person so careful to make a good impression that he chokes off his own personality makes a poor one.

Worry belongs before the bet, not after. Act, then correct — and stop running a review after every action.

6 **Happiness is a symptom, not a wage**

Happiness is not earned or deserved, and no more a moral issue than the circulation of the blood. Since man is a goal-striving being, happiness is what functioning normally feels like.

Treat happiness as payment for unselfishness and the logic ends somewhere absurd — if misery earns happiness, the more wretched you make yourself the happier you should become.

Stop waiting to deserve pleasant thoughts. When happiness is missing, check first whether you are actively striving at something; that is usually what has gone.

DEFINITIONS + DISTINCTIONS

The vocabulary the argument runs on

Most of these come from engineering. They are meant as mechanical terms, not metaphors.

Cybernetics	From the Greek for steersman. The study of self-steering systems that correct course from feedback.
Servo-mechanism	A guidance system that automatically finds its way to a target, correcting as it goes. The model for the brain and nervous system.
Self-image	The master goal-picture: your idea of the kind of person you are. It prescribes the area of the possible.
Forebrain thinking	Conscious deliberation. It poses problems, gathers information, sets goals and forms judgments. It is the operator, not the machine.
Negative feedback	Course-correcting criticism. Necessary — nothing can be steered without it.
Excessive negative feedback	The same signal turned up until it stops forward motion instead of adjusting it. The account of inhibition here.
Poise	The deliberate shunting aside of fears and uncertainties about new and uncontrollable circumstances.
Self-acceptance	Coming to terms with yourself as you are now, faults included. Distinct from self-improvement, and its precondition.
The winning feeling	A sign that the mechanism is set for success. A symptom, not the cause.

THE ACTIONS

Five things to actually do

1 Thirty minutes in the theatre

Alone and undisturbed, at a reserved time you protect every day, close your eyes and picture yourself in the role you want — in physical detail. The room, the furniture, the lighting. Then watch yourself acting and reacting inside it, appropriately and successfully.

It is working when the picture arrives faster and holds more detail, and you catch yourself behaving that way outside the session.

The specification is that you see yourself behaving successfully, not merely possessing the outcome. Picturing the office is not the exercise; picturing how you run the meeting is.

2 Run the four questions on a belief

Any time you notice yourself hanging back from something, find the “I can't” underneath it and ask whether it rests on fact or assumption. Then, in order: is there any rational reason for this belief? Could I be mistaken in it? Would I reach the same conclusion about someone else in the same situation? And why go on acting as if it were true, if there is no good reason to believe it?

It is working when you can state the belief in one plain sentence — and it does not survive the third question.

3 Do the worrying before the bet

On every committed course of action, load the anxiety into the planning stage. Once the decision is made and execution begins, dismiss responsibility and care about the outcome, and let the machinery run.

It is working when ordinary work stops carrying a running commentary about how it will turn out.

The precondition is real work first — intense interest, the facts gathered, the courses of action considered. Releasing before that is not release; it is avoidance.

4 Bank the hits

Before anything new, and at the start of any long effort, deliberately recall past successes and the feelings that went with them. Use errors to correct course and then dismiss them. And arrange your daily work so you succeed at small things.

It is working when you begin new things holding evidence rather than dread.

5 The twenty-one-day experiment

As a deliberate twenty-one-day block rather than an open-ended intention, change which shoe goes on first and how you tie the laces, and use the altered act as a daily trigger. Then hold the day to eight resolutions: be cheerful; act friendlier; be less critical and place the best interpretation on what others do; act as if success were inevitable; refuse to color facts pessimistically; smile three times; react calmly whatever happens; ignore negative facts you can do nothing about.

At the end, run the test proposed for it: check whether worry, guilt and hostility have diminished and confidence has risen.

Twenty-one days is Maltz's figure for how long the experiment should run, not an established finding about habit formation.

QUICK REFERENCE

One page

THE MECHANISM

- It is impersonal. It steers to whatever target you load.
- It aims at pictures, not instructions.
- The master picture is your self-image.
- Its only input is your beliefs and interpretations.
- Its signal when set right is the winning feeling.

SUCCESS

- Sense of direction · Understanding · Courage · Charity
- Esteem · Self-confidence · Self-acceptance

FIVE RULES FOR FREEING THE MACHINERY

- Worry before the bet, not after.
- Respond to the present moment; it cannot work tomorrow.
- One thing at a time.
- Sleep on it.
- Relax while you work.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS

- Is there any rational reason for this belief?
- Could I be mistaken in it?
- Would I conclude this about someone else in the same situation?
- Why act as if it were true with no good reason to believe it?

TWO LINES TO KEEP

- You may have made a mistake. That does not make you a mistake.
- It does not matter who is right, but what is right.

The whole argument in one line: the machine is impersonal, it aims at pictures, and the master picture is you.